



The rest of the settlements are some 400 coastal villages. In the 19th century the islands were split into two, Western and Eastern Samoa, and came under the ownership of Germany and the US. In 1962

Western Samoa became an independent nation once again. While Eastern, or American, Samoa has become industrial, Western Samoa, or Samoa, has retained a very traditional lifestyle.

SAMOAN TATTOOS

The Samoans are probably the most famous tattooists of the South Pacific with their striking patterns and designs. Not many Polynesian words have entered the English language, but one that has is *tattoo*.



1 Tattooing ceremony

Traditional tattoos are done using boar-tooth needles dipped in soot-based ink. Songs are often sung to the recipient to take their mind off the pain.



2 Soothing the tattoos

After the tattoo is finished, the tattooist rubs coconut oil into the designs. Traditional tattooing can take many weeks to complete, but these days they use methods that take a shorter time.



3 The designs

The male tattoos stretch from the knee up to the lower back and the stomach, resembling a pair of shorts. The female tattoos tend to be on the wrists or above the knee.



RELIGION

The Samoans are devout Christians and have been ever since the Christian missionaries arrived in about 1830. Samoa's motto is "Samoa is founded on God". Churches tend to be the grandest buildings in the village and everyone wears white to the services.

FISHING IN PAOPAO

Traditional fishing gear—fish hooks and octopus lures—are still used on Samoa, especially in villages. The skills are passed on through experience and practice and learned from generation to generation. The boats they use are *vaa'alo* (outriggers) and the smaller *paopao*.



TOURISM

The tourist industry is one of the most important income generators to the economy of Samoa, and the government puts heavy emphasis on it. The Samoans welcome tourists into their homes and allow them to become involved in ceremonies and the traditional way of life.

Samoan women wear traditional dresses made from woven matting or leaves.

